

SERVING PLAN 2 SERVING PLAN

Pesto Chicken Penne

with Tomatoes and Shaved Parmesan

We're sure you're just as familiar with penne pasta as you are with basil pesto, but did you know that the diagonally-cut noodles are named after the pointy tip of a pen? In this repeat recipe, heavy cream and pesto create a luxurious complement to chicken, fresh spinach, tomatoes, and whole-wheat penne. This variant is called penne *rigate* for its outer ridges, which easily hold onto the silky sauce.

25–35 minutes 910 calories per serving

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MEALS WORTH MAKING

Ingredients

- 3 ounces baby spinach
- ¼ pint grape tomatoes
- 1 yellow onion
- 2 boneless skinless chicken breasts
- 6 ounces whole-wheat penne pasta
- 3 packets unsalted butter
- ¼ cup white wine
- 1 container heavy cream
- ¼ cup pesto
- 1 ounce shaved Parmesan cheese

You'll need

10" large pot
12" large pan

Recipe tips

Be sure to read through the entire recipe before you begin cooking.

Starchy pasta cooking water will make your sauce silky and help it cling to the noodles. It's easiest to reserve this water in a liquid measuring cup, if you have one.

Deglazing is a technique in which adding liquid, like wine, to the pan after cooking protein loosens any browned bits stuck to the bottom. Scrape them up into your sauce—they are full of flavor.

The chicken might have a slight odor as a natural reaction to its vacuum packing. USDA recommends cooking chicken to 165°F.

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1. Prepare ingredients

Bring a large pot of water to a boil over high heat. Rinse all produce. Pat **spinach** dry with paper towel. Halve **tomatoes**. Peel **onion**, halve, and thinly slice.



2. Cook chicken

Pat **chicken** dry with paper towel and season all over with **½ teaspoon salt** and **pepper** as desired. Heat **2 teaspoons olive oil** in a large pan over medium-high heat. When oil is shimmering, add **chicken** and sear until cooked through and no longer pink, about 6 minutes per side. Transfer **chicken** to cutting board and set aside to rest. Reserve pan, off heat, for Step 4.



3. Cook penne

While chicken cooks, season boiling water generously with **salt**. Stir in **penne** and cook until al dente, 6–7 minutes. Reserve **½ cup pasta cooking water**, then drain and set aside (see recipe tip).



4. Sauté onion

Place pan from chicken over medium heat with **butter**. When butter is foamy, add **onion**; sauté, stirring, until soft and translucent, 4–5 minutes. Add **white wine** and cook, scraping up browned bits from bottom of pan, until liquid is reduced by half, 1–2 minutes more (see recipe tip). Meanwhile, cut rested **chicken** into ¼-inch slices.



5. Season penne

To pan with onion, still over medium heat, add cooked **penne** and **2 tablespoons heavy cream**; stir to combine. Add **¼ cup reserved pasta cooking water** (reserve remainder) and stir to coat noodles with sauce, 1–2 minutes more. Remove pan from heat. Save remaining cream for another use (it's a great match for the pesto here, but also adds a little decadence to tomato-based pasta sauces).



6. Plate pesto chicken penne

Add **pesto**, **spinach**, **tomatoes**, and sliced **chicken** to pan with penne, still off heat. Stir vigorously to fully coat with pesto, then add **remaining pasta cooking water**, 1 tablespoon at a time, until sauce is silky. Taste and add **salt** and **pepper** as desired, then divide between serving bowls. Garnish with **Parmesan** and dig in!

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